

NAXALITE MOVEMENT

■ By Amarnath K. Menon

Forty years after the Naxal movement's chief ideologue Charu Mazumdar, acolyte Kanu Sanyal and hatchet man Jangal Santhal shouted slogans like "power flows through the barrel of the gun" and "China's chairman Mao is our chairman", their extremism continues to inspire many to subscribe, though mainly in thought, to their violent ways. Naxalism gets its name from May 1967's peasant uprising at Naxalbari in Darjeeling, West Bengal, which led to the founding of the CPI (Marxist-Leninist). It still thrives in the new avatar of Left-wing extremism.

It started when three sharecroppers lifted 300

mounds of paddy from the granary of a jotedar with the support of 150 CPI(M) workers armed with lathis, bows and arrows. The initial dithering of the authorities added momentum to the Naxalite movement, which lasted 52 days before the state came down heavily on the radicals, killing 20 of them. With the Chinese communist newspaper, *People's Daily*, eulogising it as "spring thunder" over India, the movement spread to new areas in other states. While sustained and strong police action kept it under check in West Bengal, the release of the Naxalite leaders after the CPI(M) tasted power at the ballot for the first time in 1969, gave the movement a

749

people were killed in Naxal violence in 2006, with maximum deaths in Chhattisgarh

Red CORRIDOR

Four decades after they sounded the war cry of a new democratic revolution, the Naxalites have become a resounding question mark on India's democratic existence

GUN POINT: Rebels in the Abujh Marsh forests of Chhattisgarh during an exercise

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